Week 1: Understanding Key Concepts in Library and Information Science

Introduction

Library and Information Science (LIS) is a dynamic and evolving discipline that supports knowledge creation, access, organisation, and preservation. To fully appreciate the scope and relevance of LIS, it is crucial to begin by understanding the foundational terms that define the field: Information, Library, Library Science, and Information Science. These concepts are distinct yet deeply interconnected, forming the bedrock upon which LIS as a profession and academic discipline is built.

Conceptual Definitions

Information

Information refers to processed data that has meaning and can be used to inform, instruct, or guide decision-making. It is the end product of organising, interpreting, and contextualising raw data. Information may be textual, visual, audio, digital, or symbolic, and it plays a central role in every field of human endeavour—from education and communication to governance and science.

- Key Characteristics of Information:

• Relevance

• Accuracy

• Timeliness

• Completeness

• Accessibility

- Forms of Information:

• Formal: Books, academic journals, government publications.

• Informal: Social media updates, conversations, personal letters.

• Tangible: Printed documents, CDs, newspapers.

• Intangible: Spoken words, ideas, or electronic content.

- Importance of Information:

• Facilitates learning and research

• Supports decision-making and planning

• Enables communication and knowledge sharing

• Drives innovation and development

Library

A library is a curated collection of information resources—such as books, periodicals, maps, audiovisual materials, and digital content—that are organised systematically for access and use. Libraries serve individuals and communities by facilitating learning, research, leisure, cultural development, and access to information.

Libraries may exist in physical buildings or digital platforms and are typically managed by trained professionals known as librarians. Libraries can be general-purpose or highly specialised depending on the user community they serve.

Types of Libraries

Below is a detailed explanation of the various types of libraries based on purpose, users, and structure:

Libraries are classified based on the communities they serve, the nature of their collections, and their functional goals. The major types of libraries include:

1. Academic Libraries

Academic libraries are established within institutions of higher learning such as universit ies, polytechnics, and colleges of education. Their primary role is to support the teaching, learning, and research missions of the parent institution. These libraries provide access t o scholarly resources such as textbooks, journals, theses, databases, and special collecti ons.

Example: The University of Lagos Library, Yaba College of Technology Library.

Key Features:

1. Serves students, faculty, and researchers
2. Offers interlibrary loan services
3. Often has subject-specific departmental libraries

2. Public Libraries

Public libraries are open to the general public and are usually funded by government bod ies. They serve people of all ages, educational backgrounds, and interests. Their purpose is to promote literacy, lifelong learning, and access to information that empowers comm unities.

Example: Lagos State Library Board, Enugu State Central Library.

Key Features:

1. Free access to resources
2. Community-focused services (e.g., literacy programmes, local history archives)
3. May offer access to the internet and technology

3. School Libraries

School libraries are found in primary and secondary schools. They support the school cu rriculum by providing pupils and teachers with books and non-book materials. These libr

aries aim to inculcate reading habits in children and improve their academic performanc e.

Example: Library at Federal Government College, Odogbolu.

Key Features:

1. Focus on age-appropriate materials
2. Supports teaching and learning
3. Helps develop early information literacy skills

4. Special Libraries

Special libraries are established to meet the specific information needs of particular orga nisations, institutions, or professional groups. They are often found in government agen cies, research institutions, hospitals, legal firms, corporate bodies, and media houses.

Examples: Nigerian Institute of Medical Research Library, Nigerian Law Reform Commiss ion Library.

Key Features:

1. Specialised collection
2. Serves a defined audience (e.g., lawyers, engineers, journalists)
3. Often restricted access to staff or members

5. National Libraries

The national library of a country is a legal depository of all published materials within th at nation. It plays a key role in preserving the nation's cultural and intellectual heritage. In Nigeria, the National Library of Nigeria performs this role and is responsible for compilin g the national bibliography.

Example: National Library of Nigeria (headquartered in Abuja).

Key Features:

1. Legal deposit function (receives copies of all books published in the country)
2. Compiles national bibliographies
3. Coordinates library development and standards nationwide

6. Research Libraries

Research libraries focus on supporting advanced study and in-depth research. They typically have extensive and highly specialised collections, including rare books, manuscripts, archives, and grey literature.

Examples: Nigerian Institute of Social and Economic Research (NISER) Library, Nigerian Institute for Oceanography and Marine Research Library.

Key Features:

1. Rich in primary sources and technical reports
2. Access may be restricted to researchers
3. Often affiliated with research institutes

7. Digital or Virtual Libraries

A digital library exists online and provides access to electronic resources such as e-books, online journals, digital archives, databases, and multimedia content. These libraries may complement or replace traditional libraries, especially in distance learning environments.

Examples: HINARI, JSTOR, Nigerian Virtual Library.

Key Features:

1. Accessible via the internet
2. Requires ICT skills for navigation
3. Offers 24/7 access to users with login credentials

8. Private Libraries

Private libraries are owned by individuals, families, or non-governmental organisations. T hough not usually open to the general public, they may reflect the owner's personal intere sts or special areas of expertise.

Example: Personal library of Wole Soyinka or Chinua Achebe.

Key Features:

1. Restricted access
2. Highly personal and curated collections
3. May include rare or autographed materials

9. Mobile Libraries

Mobile libraries are designed to take library services to underserved or remote areas usin g vehicles like vans, carts, or boats. They are important tools for promoting reading and i nformation access in rural communities.

Examples: Book buses in Northern Nigeria, UNICEF mobile library projects.

Key Features:

1. Portable and flexible
2. Brings books to users who cannot access physical libraries
3. Especially important in rural education initiatives

10. Parliamentary and Legislative Libraries

These are libraries established within the legislative arm of government to provide lawm akers with information to support decision-making, legislative drafting, and policy analys is.

Example: National Assembly Library, State House of Assembly Libraries.

Key Features:

1. Holds legal documents, bills, gazettes, and debates
2. Staffed by trained legal or legislative librarians
3. Confidential and time-sensitive services

Library Science

Library Science is the field of study and practice that deals with the principles, theories, and techniques of organising, managing, and delivering library services. It involves activities such as cataloguing, classification, user services, collection development, information retrieval, and preservation.

Library Science focuses largely on traditional information environments—primarily print-based resources—and is concerned with how best to manage and facilitate access to these resources in a structured and user-friendly way.

Core Functions of Library Science:

1. Acquisition and organisation of information resources
2. Reference and information services
3. Cataloguing and classification
4. Library management and administration
5. User education and information literacy

Information Science

Information Science is an interdisciplinary field that explores how information is created, processed, stored, retrieved, and used. It incorporates principles from computer science, cognitive psychology, linguistics, statistics, and communication studies to develop systems and tools for managing information efficiently.

While Library Science is more rooted in the management of physical resources, Informati

on Science focuses on information systems, digital resources, artificial intelligence, and user behaviour.

Components of Information Science:

1. Information architecture and retrieval
2. Database design and management
3. Artificial Intelligence in information processing
4. Human-computer interaction
5. Data analytics and information systems

Key Focus Areas:

1. Understanding user needs and behaviour
2. Designing and evaluating information systems
3. Developing digital libraries and platforms
4. Analysing the life cycle of information